THE BATTLE OF SALAMIS

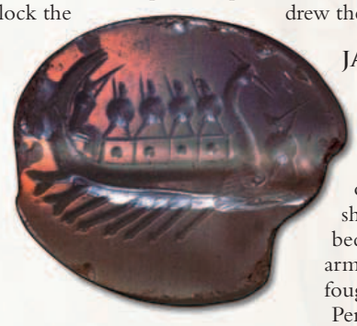
In September 480 BCE the Greek city-states resisting invasion by the Persian Emperor Xerxes were facing defeat. As the Persian army pressed southward, Athens evacuated its population to the island of Salamis, where the Greek fleet assembled in Paloukia Bay. Athens duly fell to Xerxes, who felt confident that the conquest of Greece was close to being accomplished.

FAITH IN THE ORACLE

The Greek fleet's Spartan commander, Eurybiades, favored withdrawal, but the Athenian Themistocles argued they should stand and fight. He invoked a recent prophecy by the Delphic oracle, that Greece would be saved by a "wooden wall." He claimed that this referred to the Greek ships and, since he controlled the Athenian triremes, around half of the entire Greek naval force, his voice prevailed. Xerxes, meanwhile, was bent upon finishing off the Greeks as quickly as possible. He was only worried that their fleet might slip away before he could crush it.

To stand a chance of victory, Themistocles needed to negate the Persians' numerical advantage—perhaps three ships to one. He planned to induce Xerxes to divide his fleet. An agent was sent to the Persian emperor, pretending to be a deserter. He told Xerxes that the Greeks were on the point of withdrawing. Xerxes responded exactly as Themistocles would have wished. One squadron of Persian ships was dispatched to block the western end of the Megarian Strait, another sent to patrol the southern coast of Salamis. During the night his other two squadrons were ordered out to patrol the eastern end of the strait.

At dawn these two Persian squadrons headed into the strait toward Paloukia Bay, but their oarsmen were tired after their night's exertions. The Greeks, who had slept soundly on shore, pushed off from the beach, fresh and ready for battle. The Persians heard them approaching before they saw them, a cacophony of war songs and bugles echoing out from the sheltered bay. The Greeks emerged from behind the island at the mouth of the bay a little too quickly. Wanting to stay close to shore, where the Persians could not use their numbers to outflank them, the Greeks had to back oars momentarily—giving an impression of hesitation or flight that drew the Persians forward.



Saviors of Greece
This amber seal is carved with a striking image of a trireme with a row of armed hoplites on its deck. It dates from the time of the battle of Salamis.

JARRING CLASH

The Greek triremes maneuvered to smash their bronze rams into the hulls of the larger Persian ships. Where galleys became entangled, armored Greek hoplites fought face to face with Persian soldiers, while arrows and spears rained down on both sides. The sea was littered with broken oars, wreckage, and the bodies of the slain. To the dismay of Xerxes, watching the battle from a hilltop on the shore, his right wing gave way under the battering from the Athenian triremes on the Greek left. His commander, Ariabignes, was killed and central control rapidly disintegrated. As the Athenians swung around to attack the Persian center and right from the flank and rear, the battle turned into a rout, with surviving Persian ships escaping as best they could. Salamis ended Xerxes' attempt to conquer Greece. It was the first decisive naval battle in history.



THE BATTLE OF SALAMIS

Date	480 BCE
Location	Off the island of Salamis, Greece
Result	Greek victory

COMBATANTS

GREEK CITY-STATES	PERSIAN EMPIRE

COMMANDERS

Eurybiades Themistocles	Ariabignes

FORCES

Ships: 300–380 triremes	**Ships:** 700–1,000

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** c.40	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** c.200

Serried ranks of galleys
In the narrow straits where the battle of Salamis was fought, the smaller Greek triremes proved far more maneuverable than the larger galleys employed by the Persians.

